EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

How Can God Know Our Choices?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 4:4-5

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 4 (Obedience and Disobedience, Compulsion and Justice), the end of Chapter 4 (with the other Rishonim on foreknowledge) and Chapter 5, questions 1 to 4

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 25 November 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Essay 4 So Far

- **Chapters 1-2:** man is **the pinnacle of creation**, and for Saadia the whole universe was created for him. Some Rishonim disagreed, but **everyone agrees** that *bechirah*, free choice, was given to the human.
- **Chapter 3:** free will covers **abstaining** as well as acting; it comes **before** the action, not simultaneously or, "even more absurdly," after it; and only a **conscious** act counts. Leaning back and switching on a light is not even *shogeg*; there is no sacrifice for it, because it is not called an action. "That underscores Saadia's principle of *bechirah*."
- **Chapter 4:** proofs of free will from **sense, logic, Scripture and tradition** ("choose life"; "everything is in the hands of Heaven except the fear of Heaven"). Then two questions: why Hashem allows evil (it is not bad **for Him**; it is our arena of choice), and the famous question, which **Saadia is the first on record to ask**: how can Hashem know everything, and we still be free?

Tonight the Rabbi first completed that topic with the other Rishonim, then began Chapter 5.

Part 1: Approach 1, Saadia: He Knows the Choice

Both are true. We have complete free will, and Hashem knows the future. What He knows is **what we will choose**: after all our deliberations, He knew from the beginning where we would end up. He watches from the side. Our freedom is intact and so is His perfect knowledge.

The difficulties

As discussed last week:

- **We become actors.** "When we're really confronted with a choice, going forwards and backwards, should I, shouldn't I, we know deep down at the end of the day **someone already knows** what I'm going to choose. That's quite defeating."
- **Why live it out?** The purpose of this world is to go through the battle of choice and **incorporate goodness within us**. If Hashem knows every choice, He could simulate our lives. "Okay, we can get

around that somewhat": we have to **actually do and experience** choosing the right thing, not just have it simulated. "Fine, that's somewhat understandable. But it's hard to accept that this is the only way to reconcile the contradiction."

Part 2: Approach 2, Rabbeinu Bachya and the Rambam: Both True, Beyond Us

Rabbeinu Bachya: accept both

Chovot HaLevavot was one of the next to discuss it, "and he really gave up." We don't know exactly how it works, but we know **God is just and trustworthy**, and He told us about reward and punishment. **The best approach is to accept** that we have full choice and will be rewarded or punished, **and** that Hashem knows all. Our understanding is limited. If there were an explanation humans could understand, God would have revealed it to us. "Accept it. Move on."

"Rabbeinu Bachya was a philosopher. But he recognises that **sometimes it's better to have a good question unresolved than a weak answer** to the question."

The Rambam: the answer lies in Hashem's knowledge

"Maybe Rabbeinu Bachya meant what the Rambam was going to write. The Rambam says something very similar, but much deeper, and people who didn't understand him thought he was saying something very simple." (Those at the Tuesday night shiur on Hilchot Teshuvah had seen it.)

1. **Both are true:** humans must have free will, and Hashem must know the future, or His knowledge would be imperfect.
2. **The question assumes we understand Hashem's knowledge.** But we cannot understand His essence, as we saw in Saadia's Essay 1, and **His attributes are part of His essence**. So we cannot understand His ***yedi'ah*** and ***chochmah*** either.
3. **We ask from a human perspective.** Humans live in **past, present and future**, so we see a contradiction. Hashem does not live in time.
4. **If we could understand His knowledge, we would see how the two are reconciled.** With our human minds, in time, we cannot.

The Mishnah says it explicitly:

הכל צפוי והרשות נתונה

Everything is foreseen, and permission is given. (Rabbi Akiva, Avot 3:15)

The commentators say this is exactly the Rambam's point: both are true, and how they fit is beyond the human mind.

The Ra'avad misread him

The Ra'avad, the Rambam's critic, thought the Rambam was simply raising the question and saying he couldn't answer it, and objected: **if you can't answer a question, don't raise it**. His own answer is very like Saadia's, and at the end he admits he does not really like it. "But the truth is the Ra'avad didn't understand the Rambam. He had a lot of depth there."

Part 3: Approaches 3 and 4: Limiting One Principle

The first two approaches **keep both principles** and reconcile them. The next two **limit one of them**.

Approach 3, the Ralbag: Hashem withdraws His knowledge

The Ralbag, Rabbi Levi ben Gershon (Gersonides): philosopher, mathematician, astronomer, commentator on the Torah, "an incredible mind. If you think the Rambam was a rationalist, the Ralbag was much more of a rationalist." And yet he "comes up with the following phenomenal approach":

- To allow humans free will, **Hashem limited His knowledge of our future choices**. He knows our actions as we do them, and everything is taken into account, but **as it were, He withdrew Himself** (*tzimtzum*) from knowing in advance what we will choose.
- **That is not an imperfection, because He chose it.**

The parable of the wealthy father. I am the wealthiest man and could support everyone in the world. I decide, so that my son will learn to make his own way, **to leave him in poverty** to work his way up. That does not diminish my wealth. At any moment I could say, "Son, come back to the palace." I have **willingly chosen** not to. So too, it would be an imperfection if Hashem **could not** know; it is not one if He **chooses** not to.

An echo of the Arizal, about 300 years later. The Arizal asked how anything, even humans or evil, can exist if Hashem's essence permeates everything, and answered with ***tzimtzum***: Hashem withdrew Himself. "That's a much broader thing. The Ralbag says it on one very specific matter: Hashem's knowledge of our future actions."

Approach 4, Chasdai Crescas: He knows us completely

Chasdai Crescas, 14th century, from Zaragoza, author of ***Or Hashem***, *The Light of Hashem*. He limits the other principle. Hashem is perfect, so He knows our choices. In what sense are we free?

"Perhaps the most difficult approach to accept and understand." **Hashem understands every human being so completely that He can predict exactly what he or she will choose.**

"Flora, this is what you touched on last week": the mother who sends her child to the shop with a pound and **just knows** he'll come back with sweets. She has no magical powers. She knows how he grew up, his challenges, his choices. **Does the child have free will? Of course.** At any moment he could do what his mother said. But looking from the side, she knows what he'll choose. So too Hashem, with total knowledge, **knows** rather than guesses.

"If we could input every single aspect of a human being's identity, where you were born, what kind of parents you had, how many siblings, which synagogue, which school, which culture, we'd be able to predict how that person would respond to any situation. There is talk about this nowadays. Already there are things that can tell you all your political views from ten answers. Same idea, much deeper."

The problem: this is **very deterministic**. If our choices are the product of millions of factors, upbringing, family, community, social identity, then **we are programmed**. "It might answer the contradiction, but it leaves you with another question: in what sense do we really have free will?"

The four approaches

	Approach	Free will	Foreknowledge
1	**Saadia**	Complete	Hashem knows **the outcome of our deliberation**; knowing is not causing
2	**Rabbeinu Bachya and the Rambam**	Complete	Complete. Reconciled **from Hashem's perspective**, beyond time, not from ours. "Everything is foreseen and permission is given"
3	**The Ralbag**	Complete	Hashem **voluntarily withdraws** His knowledge of our future choices
4	**Chasdai Crescas**	Real but conditioned	Hashem **knows us so completely** He knows what we will choose. "He spoke about AI."

"Those are basically the four main approaches in the Rishonim. The later discussion really goes around these four."

From the class: AI and 100%

Chaim said this is exactly AI today. The Rabbi: we are not yet at the stage where inputting your age, parents, siblings, community and education predicts you; it would be more likely to be right, "but still not 100%." Chaim: only at 100% do you truly have no choice, and 100% is only Hashem. The Rabbi stressed how nuanced humans are: two people with the same school, synagogue and community, one of whom had **a single different experience**, may respond quite differently. "One tiny permutation can change the whole equation."

The Rabbi's own view: "If you ask me my best understanding, it's certainly **the Rambam's approach**. That for me makes the most sense, and I think it's very deep."

Part 4: Chapter 5, Question 1: Why Command the Righteous?

Chapters 5 and 6 remain. Chapter 5 asks **seven questions** on free will; Chapter 6 takes **verses** that seem to contradict it. "Again Saadia takes a very, very strict approach: we have full free will, and he tries not to limit it at all."

The question: if Hashem knows the righteous person **will** do the right thing (He told Avraham to bind his son, and he did), **what is the point of commanding him?** "I don't fully understand what the question is," the Rabbi admitted, but Saadia gives four answers:

1. **To know what is right.** The righteous person needs to know what Hashem wants.
2. **To reward him properly.** The Gemara says **greater is one who is commanded and does than one who is not commanded and does**.
3. **Symmetry.** If Hashem rewarded what He never commanded because He knew it would be done, He would also have to punish for what He never forbade. That is not right, so He discloses both the good and the bad.
4. **Encouragement.** Hearing that Hashem commands it encourages us. **I warned him, and so he will live.**

Rav Yosef the blind

The Rabbi told the Gemara's story. **Rav Yosef was blind**, and there was a debate whether a blind person is obligated in mitzvot.

- **At first** he said: whoever tells me the halacha is that **a blind person is exempt**, I'll make a party. I keep all the mitzvot anyway; if I'm exempt and still do them, think how much reward I'll get!
- **Then he changed his mind:** I'll make a party for whoever tells me **a blind person is obligated**. When you are commanded, there are greater challenges, a greater pull not to do it, so **the reward is greater**.

Part 5: Question 2: Why Warn the Wicked?

If Hashem knows the wicked will **not** listen, why send prophets to call them to teshuvah? Saadia gives **seven answers** (the Rabbi noted a missing line in the printed text and supplied it from his own edition):

#	Answer
1	**No excuse.** Otherwise the wicked could say, "Had You sent me prophets, had You told me off, I wouldn't have done it." So Hashem, "as it were, covers Himself"
2	**Punishment is for what happens, not what would happen.** Without a warning, Hashem would be punishing them for what He knows they **would** have done had He warned them. Reward and punishment are not based on potential
3	**Completeness.** Just as Hashem gave proofs of His existence (Essay 1), and some still deny Him, there should be wide-ranging statements of His will, for believers and deniers alike
4	**A command has its own value.** If I tell you to do something bad and you don't, I am still wrong and foolish for saying it. So a command to do good is still wise, even if it is ignored
5	**Otherwise a command's worth depends on obedience.** If a good command ignored is "pointless," then a bad command obeyed would be "worthwhile." That is ridiculous
6	**Equality.** Hashem gave the wicked and the righteous the same reason and ability, so He gives both the same commands
7	**A lesson for others.** "Perhaps the best answer." Even if the command is worthless to the wicked man, **everyone else sees** that he was commanded, did not listen, and was punished. "People still talk about the Flood, about Sedom." It teaches the righteous and future generations

Answer 2 and last week's problem

"This is an important point." It comes back to the Rabbi's problem from last week: if Hashem knows what we will choose, why live through the world at all? Here Saadia gives his answer: **Hashem does not reward and punish based on potential or simulation**, on "if I created this kind of human he would choose A, B and C through billions of choices." He rewards and punishes **what actually happens**. "We have to go through it."

Part 6: Questions 3 and 4: Decreed Death, Human Murder

"A very interesting question." Questions three and four are really one.

Question 3. Suppose Hashem has decreed a person must die this year, as punishment or as a trial. A wicked person comes and kills him, as **Izevel killed the prophets**. To whom do we attribute the act? Izevel could argue she was merely fulfilling the word of God.

Question 4. Hashem decrees that a person will lose £1,000 this year, and **a thief** burgles £1,000 from him. Is the theft Hashem's act?

Saadia's answer: the **outcome** is Hashem's decree; **the way it happens is the human's act**.

- The person was to die, but **he could have died in many ways**, naturally in his bed, not waking in the morning. That he died **this way** is the murderer's doing.
- "You're going to lose £1,000, yes. But you could have **paid lots of parking fines this year**, been caught in lots of bus lanes. Someone decides to steal from you; that's his problem. Hashem has many ways."

Shmaya and Achiya

Saadia brings the two brothers **Shmaya and Achiya** before the king of Edom, that is, Rome, told in the Gemara (**Ta'anit 18b**). The king said: do a miracle; let your God save you, as He saved Chananyah, Mishael and Azaryah from the fire. They replied:

They were perfectly righteous and fit for a miracle. **We are not**, and we are deserving of death. If you do not kill us, Hashem has **many bears and many lions** to punish us with. **We were handed to you only so that you would be punished for our blood.**

"Yes, we deserve to die. But why does it have to be **you**?"

From the class

Flora recalled a Gemara: even those like **Nevuchadnezzar** or **Pharaoh**, who carried out what was decreed, were punished **because they overstepped**, acting with needless cruelty. The Rabbi agreed: that is the answer of **the Ra'avad** and **the Ramban**, seen on Tuesday night with the Rambam's question of why Egypt was punished when Avraham had been told his descendants would be enslaved for 400 years. **They went overboard.**

Part 7: The Rabbi's Problem: The £5,000 Gift

"I'll tell you the problem I have with this."

Hashem decrees that a poor man will receive **£5,000 more** this year than last. I see he has been struggling, and out of the goodness of my heart I give him £5,000 of charity. By Saadia's logic, **he would have got his £5,000 with me or without me**, just as the victim would have died with or without the murderer. If he'd won the lottery or found it on the floor, the outcome is the same.

So human action **becomes a bit meaningless**. "I could easily say at the back of my mind: if I step back now and don't give him £1,000, someone else will." And all my actions are **just fulfilling decrees of God**, "which again I find difficult. It comes back to Saadia's answer on foreknowledge: an **actor** idea, that we're just acting out what Hashem has already decreed."

Participants pushed back:

- **You are the one who listened first.** Hashem's will is that he gets the money; how it happens is up to people, and you were the first to fulfil it.
- **Action moulds the man.** It doesn't matter that someone else would have done it; the giving shapes **you**. "It's not about brownie points." The more mitzvot you do, the more accustomed you become to doing good, and that is why there are poor people: **so we have the chance to give**.

The Rabbi agreed it is good, "of course it's good, I'm not telling you not to do it," but held to his point: "I'm essentially acting out what would have happened anyway. Yes, I did it and I get the credit, fantastic. But it would have happened anyway." There are other approaches, which he promised for next week.

Summary

1. **Four approaches to foreknowledge and free will:** Saadia (He knows the **outcome** of our choice); Rabbeinu Bachya and **the Rambam** (both true, reconciled only from Hashem's timeless perspective, "everything is foreseen and permission is given"; the Ra'avad misread it); **the Ralbag** (Hashem **voluntarily withdraws** His foreknowledge, like the father who leaves his son to make his own way); **Chasdai Crescas** (He knows us **so completely** He knows our choices, which is very deterministic). The Rabbi's own preference is **the Rambam**.
2. **Why command the righteous?** To know what is right, for **greater reward** ("greater is one who is commanded"; Rav Yosef the blind), for symmetry, and for encouragement.
3. **Why warn the wicked?** Seven answers, chief among them: **no excuse**, **punishment only for what actually happens** (not for a simulation), and **a lesson for others**.
4. **Decreed outcomes, human means:** the death or loss is Hashem's decree; **how it happens is the human's act** (Shmaya and Achiya: "many bears, many lions"). Those who carry out a decree with excess cruelty are punished for that too.
5. **The Rabbi's difficulty:** if outcomes are fixed, does my charity matter? The class answered that **action moulds the man**.

Coming Up

- **Next week:** the rest of Chapter 5, with three more questions, including **Sancheriv**, and more on this theme, with a different approach to the Rabbi's question.
- **Then Chapter 6:** verses that seem to contradict free will, "very interesting to see the different approaches in the Rishonim."

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